Webster County Genealogical Society

Emergency Preparedness and Response Plan

Brittany Dueker

Updated April 22, 2025

Table of Contents

Table of Contents 2
Institution Profile 3
Emergency Preparedness Measures 4
Keep This Emergency Plan Updated 4
Collection Prioritization 5
Security 5
Emergency Kits 6
Coordinate with Library Staff 6
WCGS Member Training 6
Emergency Communication 7
Risk Assessment and Emergency Response 8
Tornadoes and other Damaging Weather 8
Flooding/Water Leak 9
Fire 10
Theft 11
Ransomware Attack 12
Pests/Infestation 13
Zombie Apocalypse 14
Collection Recovery and Salvage 15
Assessing Damaged Materials 15
Methods to Save Wet Materials 15
Emergency Response Professionals 17
Business Continuity and Institutional Resilience 17
Appendices 18
Sample Phone Tree and Emergency Contact List 18
Checklist for Emergency Kits 19

Institution Profile

The Webster County Genealogical Society (WCGS) is located in room 134 in the Fort Dodge Public Library (FDPL) building at 424 Central Ave, Fort Dodge, IA 50501. It is a small room about 500? Square feet, divided into three main sections: the entry/research area, a kitchenette with cupboards and a sink, and the shelves that house the majority of the collections.

WCGS serves the communities in Webster County, IA, as well as anyone who requests information about the area. The population of Webster County is approximately 36,000.

The materials kept by WCGS include books with a variety of cover and binding types, loose papers held in 3-ring binders, photographs, CDs, and microfilm. Some of the materials have been digitized, but not everything.

As a small not-for-profit organization, it is unlikely that there will be emergencies related to criminal activity, but natural disasters are certainly something that need to be well-prepared for. Also, since WCGS is not regularly staffed and is located in the public library building, it is important to coordinate any emergency planning with library staff to ensure any needed response is effective.

https://wcgsiowa.org/about/

Emergency Preparedness Measures

There are many strategies that can be put into place in order to prevent emergencies or reduce the harm that can be caused by them. The following procedures are useful to a wide variety of potential emergencies. Find more information on specific emergencies in the Risk Assessment section.

Keep This Emergency Plan Updated

-Review risk assessment for accuracy and relevancy

-Evaluate preparedness measures and emergency kit contents

-Update contact information as necessary

Last Plan Update Check	Changes Made	Initials

Collection Prioritization

Prioritize items first by risk

1. Items that are at direct risk of being damaged
2. damaged items
3. items that are unlikely to be damaged

Within those categories, use the following prioritization based on replace-ability:

1. Undigitized Materials, including 3-ring binders that hold record research information and correspondence
2. Microfilm and photos
3. Paper originals
4. Paper copies that are also held elsewhere
5. Other items

Each position of WCGS shall be responsible for an assigned section of the collection. In the event that a position is not currently filled or the person is unavailable, the President (or other person in charge) can assign these sections to others. If enough people are available, assign each person a section of shelving to move/repair.

[Hypothetically, here would be a color-coded floor plan dividing up the area into manageable sections.]

Security

Only authorized members of WCGS should have access to the collection. Visitors must be accompanied by a member at all times and both members and visitors should sign in and out in the guest book by the front door.

At least one copy of all digitized materials and the catalog should be stored off-site and updated weekly.

Account passwords should be changed annually.

Emergency Kits

Emergency kits should be checked quarterly to make sure all necessary items are still present and unexpired/in good condition (see Appendix). If an item is used/removed, the WCGS president should be notified and the item should be replaced promptly. There should be at least one kit available in the space at all times.

Date of Last Kit Check	Initials

Coordinate with Library Staff

Because WCGS is located in a shared space in the Fort Dodge Public Library, it is necessary to have a clear line of communication with library staff. One library staff member's contact information should be in the phone tree and the WCGS president and FDPL director should meet annually.

WCGS Member Training

Members of WCGS who have regular access to the collections should be aware of all emergency procedures. A small section of the monthly newsletter should contain information about a relevant safety/emergency issue (e.g. the location and contents of emergency kits, a reminder about sharing updated contact information for the phone tree, or where to go in the event of a tornado).

Fire and tornado drills should be scheduled annually, and WCGS should participate in any local- or state-wide drills.

Emergency Communication

In the event of an emergency, it's crucial that everyone is able to communicate. For major and moderate emergencies, use the phone tree (see Appendix) to call other members. For minor emergencies, email is acceptable. If it is necessary to inform the public, use Facebook to make a post and have a member check it regularly for responses.

Risk Assessment and Emergency Response

This section has detailed information for the likelihood that a particular emergency will happen, how severe it would be, and what to do if that emergency actually happens.

Remember, **the most valuable part of our libraries is the people**. No matter how rare, expensive, or irreplaceable something is, human life is moreso. **Do not risk your life for anything in the collection.**

Tornadoes and other Damaging Weather

Tornados and other damaging weather like derechos, hail, etcetera are a common occurrence in the Midwest. It may not be likely for any one specific location, but there were a record number of tornadoes (125) observed in Iowa in 2025 (https://www.weather.gov/dmx/iators2024), so it is good to be prepared.

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely			
Possible			x
Likely			

Emergency Response Plan

- In the event there is pending severe weather, members should use the weather radio from the Emergency Kit.
- If a severe storm or tornado warning is issued, members must go to the nearest storm shelter. [Ideally, I'd have a specific location here.]
- While visitors are strongly encouraged to also take shelter, if they choose not to, they may not stay in the room alone.
- In the event that a tornado or severe storm damages the building/collection, use the phone tree to notify members.
- Salvage wet materials using the guidelines in the Collection Recovery and Salvage section of this document

Flooding/Water Leak

Risk Assessment

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely			
Possible		x	x
Likely			

Emergency Response

- Cover materials with plastic sheeting from emergency kit to prevent them from getting wet
- Move materials away from water as quickly as possible
- Identify where the water is coming from
- Stop leak or turn off water main, if possible
- For flooding, move materials on low shelves to higher up and create barriers to prevent water from coming into the room; relocate materials if time allows
- After initial emergency response, prioritize removal of standing water, stabilization of temperature and humidity, and protection of undamaged materials; this will prevent mold growth and further damage to materials and the space
- Use appropriate PPE when handling water-damaged materials
- Salvage wet materials using the guidelines in the Collection Recovery and Salvage section of this document
- If materials need to be frozen, contact [insert local freezer guy information]

Fire

Risk Assessment

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely			
Possible			x
Likely			

Emergency Response

- In the event of a fire, exit the building and call 911 immediately; do NOT remove materials from the room at this time
- If the fire is small and/or contained (e.g. in a wastebasket) and you are comfortable doing so, use the fire extinguisher [location] to put it out; if this is unsuccessful, exit the building and call 911
- Refer to the Collection Recovery and Salvage section of this document for guidelines on treating wet materials and contact information for professional conservation organizations

Theft

Risk Assessment

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely		x	
Possible			
Likely			

Emergency Preparedness

- Members should use care to not leave items unsecured and doors unlocked
- Sign in and out all visitors to the WCGS room
- Pay attention to visitors and materials

Emergency Response

- Verify material is missing from the WCGS room and other members are not aware of its whereabouts
- Contact law enforcement

Ransomware Attack

Risk Assessment

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely	x		
Possible			
Likely			

Emergency Preparedness

- Keep regular backups of all digital information
- Change passwords regularly and don't share them
- Don't click on unfamiliar links in emails or log in to unsecure websites

Emergency Response

- Contact law enforcement
- Hope that you have recently backed up your data and the ransomware is an empty threat

Pests/Infestation

Risk Assessment

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely			
Possible			
Likely	x		

Emergency Preparedness

- Keep the WCGS room free from food/crumbs
- Clean up any spills immediately
- Monitor the room for evidence of any infestation

Emergency Response

- Remove materials that have attracted pests
- Use species-appropriate traps/sprays
- Contact professional conservators listed the Collection Recovery and Salvage section for information on how to repair damaged materials, if necessary

Zombie Apocalypse

Risk Assessment

Likelihood/Severity	Minor	Moderate	Major
Unlikely			x
Possible			
Likely			

Emergency Response

- Determine what kind of zombies you're dealing with
- Honestly, the public librarians are probably going to be your best friends in this scenario
- Pay no attention to unrealistic sci-fi media and get yourself a sturdy bicycle, an air pump, and a bike repair kit
- Is there anything in the collection that is of practical use during a zombie apocalypse? If so, take it with you. If not, pick your favorite item that you can easily carry and take that. If you can't choose, just grab the nearest small book.
- Shut off the lights and lock the door before you leave; zombies don't eat books, just brains, so if the zombie apocalypse doesn't last very long, you might be back for the collection in the near future

---

Collection Recovery and Salvage

Assessing Damaged Materials

While it may be necessary to bring in professional assistance to salvage materials in the collection, there is a lot that can (and should!) be done by WCGS members immediately. After first making sure that whatever is causing the damage has been mitigated, collect damaged materials and assess if they are salvageable or not. Then determine what treatments are suitable for the medium and if it makes sense to try to repair a particular item, given the cost of the treatment and the replace-ability of the item.

Methods to Save Wet Materials

It is possible to salvage a wet item, but immediate intervention is key. To determine the appropriate treatment, you must first identify several factors.

- Where is the water from and is it clean or dirty?
    - Sewage-contaminated water requires professional care
    - Items that are fully wet with rusty, muddy, or salty water may need to be rinsed
- Can materials begin to be dried within 48 hours?
    - If there is not enough space or people to do the work, consider freezing paper items
    - Mold is the biggest concern for wet books
- What kind of medium is the affected item?
    - Paper is relatively sturdy, but becomes fragile and heavy when wet
    - Some materials can be more harmed by potential treatments than the water itself
- How wet is the item?
    - Damp items may be easier to salvage than very wet ones
    - Very wet items may be susceptible to mold growth during the drying process or may need more treatment after being dried
    - Wet paper is fragile—handle carefully!

There are several methods available for drying wet materials.

- **Air-drying**
  - Suitable for damp or slightly wet books
  - Do not use for books printed on coated paper or with water-sensitive media
  - Control temperature and humidity in the space where possible, and keep the air moving by using fans directed parallel to the items, not directly at them
  - Stand the book on end, fan the pages, and interleave with paper towels if necessary, approximately every 20 pages
  - Replace paper towels frequently
  - To prevent distortion of pages, press books flat when they are almost dry
  - Press books overnight, set them up to dry during the day, and repeat until fully and thoroughly dry
- **Dehumidification**
  - Suitable for large amounts of damp books
  - Not recommended for wet books, or books printed on coated paper or with water-sensitive media
  - Use large commercial dehumidification systems to control temperature and humidity of a space and dry materials without moving them
  - Use of a professional vendor is encouraged for this method
- **Freezer Drying**
  - Suitable for Books, leather, parchment/vellum items, coated paper
  - Do not use for tapes, digital discs, or ambrotypes, daguerreotypes, or tintypes
  - Pack materials for freezing snugly (not tightly), putting items of similar wetness next to each other, in boxes
  - Line boxes with garbage bags if they may deteriorate when wet (e.g. cardboard boxes)
  - Create a separation between items by wrapping wax paper around them (shiny side towards the item), but do not separate items that have stuck together
  - Number the box, record identifying information for the contents of the box and their condition before taping up and sending to vendor for freezing

The information from this section was taken mostly from NEDCC preservation leaflets 3.6, 3.7, 3.8, and 3.12

Emergency Response Professionals

- Iowa Museums Archives Libraries Emergency Response Team (IMALERT) Hotline 319-384-3673 (24 hour assistance)
- National Heritage Responders (NHR)
  202-661-8068
- Northeast Document Conservation Center (NEDCC)
  nedcc.org

Business Continuity and Institutional Resilience

Build relationships with other organizations with offices in the public library building. If possible, include their members in the phone tree and support reciprocal requests.

- Fort Dodge Public Library and the City of Fort Dodge, IA
- Webster County Historical Society
- Karl King Municipal Band

Build relationships with other local organizations that have aligned goals.

- [Ideally, a list here, possibly including the historical/genealogical societies of nearby towns and neighboring counties, state cultural organizations and universities, and supportive community members.]

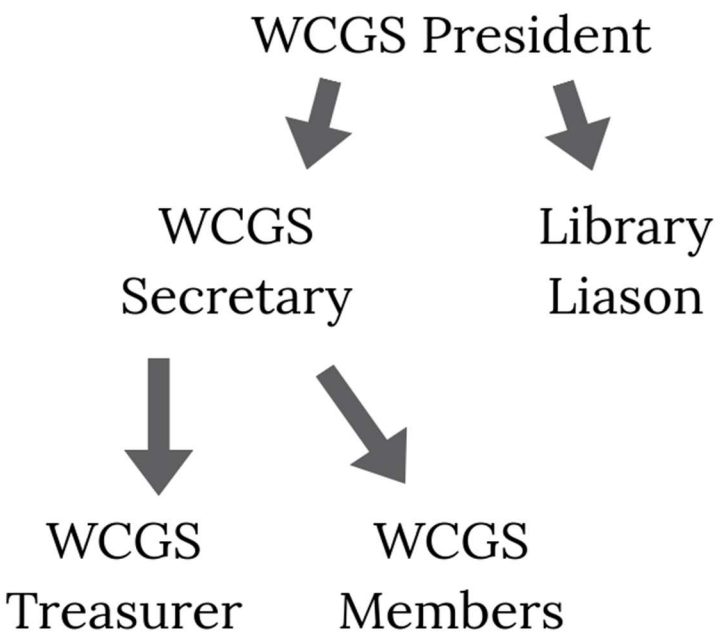
Find multiple off-site locations that could temporarily house materials and serve as a recovery/salvage workspace, in the event that the public library building is damaged.

- [Ideally, another list here.]

Continue working with the Iowa Genealogical Society to digitize collections. Also prioritize digitization of unique materials where possible.

Appendices

Sample Phone Tree and Emergency Contact List



President- Susan Pevensie (515-666-8888); webgenies@email.com

Secretary- Henry Thornmallow (015-202-0859); email2@email.com

Library Liaison- Evelyn O'Connell (251-920-6362);email3@email.com

Treasurer- Nick Carraway (059-320-1060); email4@email.com

Member 1- Winslow Houndstooth (154-148-2463); email5@email.com

Member 2- Mahit Dzmare (152-900-1587); email6@email.com

Member 3- Martine Caldwell (125-017-4666); email7@email.com

Checklist for Emergency Kits

- ❑ brightly colored bin, labelled "Emergency Kit"
- ❑ weather radio with spare batteries
- ❑ work gloves
- ❑ wax paper
- ❑ nitril gloves
- ❑ pens, pencils, and paper
- ❑ laminated floor plan
- ❑ updated contact list and phone tree, laminated or in a plastic sleeve
- ❑ plastic sheeting
- ❑ humidity and temperature monitor
- ❑ facemasks
- ❑ absorbent pads and tubes
- ❑ paper towels
- ❑ flashlight
- ❑ small hand tool kit (screwdriver, hammer, etc.)
- ❑ small electric fan
- ❑ paper towels